

STAGE FIVE • THINKING, REASONING & MENTAL MODELS

FIRSTS

DISCUSSION PROMPTS

Open-ended questions to seed group conversation beyond the worksheets

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

BY AYOMIDE AYENI

FIRSTS • Discussion Prompts

Stage Five • Thinking, Reasoning & Mental Models

PURPOSE

Individual worksheets answer “what did your decision matrix or systems map actually look like?” These prompts answer a different question: “where has this shown up in your real, lived decision-making?” They're open-ended and personal, meant to seed conversation beyond a simple share-out of worksheet answers.

This stage benefits especially from hearing other people's real examples, since abstract frameworks become genuinely memorable through concrete stories, not repetition of the definition. Use these during share-out portions, when a session finishes its planned agenda with time to spare, or when a group's energy needs a specific, real prompt.

They're organized by session, four prompts each. As always, pick the one or two that feel most alive for the room rather than working through all four every time.

Prompts by Session

SESSION 1

Foundational Mental Models

"What's a mental model you've been using your whole life without ever having a name for it?"

"Describe a decision where you later realized you'd stopped at the first cause instead of digging further. What did you miss?"

"What's a problem that felt impossible until you actually broke it into steps? What changed?"

"Have you ever tested a real assumption and been genuinely surprised by what you found?"

SESSION 2

Applied Reasoning & Reflection

"What's a bias you've caught yourself in more than once? Does naming it actually help you catch it in the moment?"

"Describe a time a problem you thought was about one person turned out to be about the whole system."

"What's feedback you received more than once before you actually did something about it? What took so long?"

"Looking back at a few real decisions, what's a mistake that shows up more than once in your own pattern?"

SESSION 3

Advanced Frameworks I

"Has first-principles thinking ever led you somewhere genuinely different from just following precedent? What happened?"

"What's a choice you made recently where you didn't clearly name what you were giving up to get it?"

"Is there a small subset of your effort that's quietly producing most of your actual results? What is it?"

"Describe a team problem you initially blamed on one person that turned out to be structural."

SESSION 4

Advanced Frameworks II

"What's a repeated task in your life that would genuinely benefit from a checklist you don't currently have?"

"Describe a skill or project where a genuine try-observe-adjust loop actually worked for you. What made it work?"

"What's an assumption you're currently building a bigger plan on top of, that you haven't actually tested yet?"

“Looking at your near-term priorities, do they genuinely connect to a longer-term goal, or have they quietly drifted?”